

MSC 323, Fall 2025-26

Theory and Analysis of Sonata Forms

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Class Hours: Monday 15:30-17:20, Thursday 10:30-12:20 (room: 336)
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COURSE DESCRIPTION. Welcome to MSC 323! In this course, we will explore the Classical style, with special attention to the so-called sonata-allegro form. Our primary goal is to gain a deeper understanding of how this style works in theory and practice. To achieve this, we will engage in close analyses, assigned readings, and compositional exercises.

COURSE STRUCTURE. The course is organized around a section-by-section study of sonata-allegro form. Our main guides will be Hepokoski & Darcy's *Sonata Theory* and Beethoven's Piano Sonatas. Alongside these, we will draw on additional repertoire by Haydn, Mozart and Beethoven. Over the semester, we will complete a full analysis of Beethoven's first twelve piano sonatas. In parallel, you will also be working week by week toward writing your own sonata movement in 18th-century Classical style. By the end of the semester, you will have completed a full sonata movement.

This is a high-intensity course. Each week you can expect:

- ~10 pages of reading
- 16–24 measures of composition
- intensive analytical work

You should anticipate 3–5 hours of focused work per week outside of class.

Important: This course requires steady, regular work. It is not possible to set the material aside and “catch up” at the end of the semester. Progress depends on weekly preparation, participation, and assignments.

REQUIRED MATERIALS. Although not a textbook per se, we will follow Hepokoski and Darcy's *Elements of Sonata Theory* throughout this course. The book will be available on the Moodle site electronically. All the readings are from this book unless otherwise indicated. You will also be given summary handouts for each chapter. However, you are expected to read some of the corresponding chapters from the book.

REQUIRED MATERIALS.

Ludwig van Beethoven, Complete Piano Sonatas and Fantasies, vol. 1 (Dover) -You can use other editions, but ensure you have measured numbers. You must obtain a copy by the second week and bring it to all the classes.

You will also be handed a course pack where you will find all the other music we will study, plus textbook summaries. I will not give you a handout every class. You should have the course pack ready in either hard copy or digital form. You can access the course pack here: <https://www.dropbox.com/s/8ccgt425goatyxk/MSC323-Full%20Package.pdf?dl=0>

All the other materials, i.e. readings and additional scores, will be available on the Moodle site.

For the assignment package, please visit:

<https://www.dropbox.com/s/awnq1y1vd6iq4nh/Assignments%20and%20Homework.pdf?dl=0>

RECOMMENDED READING

William E. Caplin. Classical Form: A Theory of Formal Functions for the Instrumental Music of Haydn, Mozart, and Beethoven. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998.

Charles Rosen, The Classical Style

Charles Rosen, The Sonata Form

GRADING.

7 Weekly analysis homework %14 (%2 each)

8 Composition Assignments %16 (%2 each)

Sonata Movement Composition %16

Midterm analysis %14

Final Paper %24

Attendance and participation: %16

FZ Policy

Students whose scores add up to less than 24 points (out of 64) by December 9th earn an FZ.

Additionally, check the table below for the absence-related FZ policy.

Weekly homework. Each week, we will be covering a sonata topic. Your weekly homework will basically be to investigate that week's topic in Beethoven's piano sonatas. Expect to work at least 3-5 hours per week outside of class for analysis and readings.

Here's what you need to do before coming to each class:

- Do the reading and prepare to discuss it in class
- Do the homework and bring it to class. You will use it in our discussions.
- Mark your scores accordingly. It will help the discussion, and eventually, we will build a complete analysis of Beethoven's first 12 sonatas.
- Hand your homework in after the class.
- Make sure to bring Beethoven's Piano Sonatas to every meeting; don't forget that's your textbook!

Midterm Assignment. The midterm will be a detailed analysis of a sonata movement.

Weekly Compositional Assignments

All compositional assignments will be announced in class, and you are expected to prepare and submit them on Mondays. If you miss a class, aren't sure about an assignment, or want some advice, just ask. You can also email your questions!

Final Paper. For the final, you're required to write an analysis paper (8 typewritten pages, excluding the bibliography, the cover, and the music examples, which should be added to the appendix). The paper could be about a piece, a concept, or a composer's particular technique or approach. Please check the appropriate sheet for further information.

Sonata Movement. You need to submit a sonata movement piece at the end of the semester and be prepared to play it or have someone else play it. Since you will be working towards the piece through your weekly assignments, ideally, the piece should have been completed by the last week. Nevertheless, you need to notate it clearly and professionally and submit a brief analysis along with

it. We will follow a strict schedule, and each section will be graded separately. Don't forget, if you wait until the last day to finish the piece, you will not receive any grades for individual steps in between.

Grading policy

1. Composition Assignments (7 total)

- Each assignment asks you to compose a sonata zone. Together, these will build into a complete sonata movement.
- Context requirement: Every submission must include the full movement as it stands so far (e.g., if you are writing the development, include your exposition too).
- Analysis required: This is an analysis class. The goal of the composition is to demonstrate your analysis through creative practice. Each submission must include an analytical commentary.
- Grading (three-tier system):
 - 0% – Not submitted.
 - 50% – Submitted but missing analysis or otherwise incomplete.
 - 100% – Submitted on time and according to instructions.
- Content grading: The individual composition assignments are not graded for their musical content. However, feedback must be incorporated as you go, because the final complete composition will be graded for content at the end of the semester.

2. Analysis Homework (7 total)

- Each homework focuses on analyzing one sonata zone in Beethoven's piano sonatas.
- Purpose: To prepare you for in-class discussion and presentation. We will go around the room, and each of you will present a piece.
- Submission: Homework will be collected at the end of class.
- Grading: Binary system
 - 0 – Not submitted.
 - 1 – Submitted (full credit).

Late Policy

Analysis Homework

- Homework must be submitted on the day of class.
- No late submissions will be accepted. The purpose of these assignments is to come to class prepared, so turning them in afterward has no value.
- If you cannot attend class, you are still responsible for sending in your homework by the deadline in order to receive credit.

Composition Assignments

- Assignments are due at the start of class on the deadline day.
- If submitted late (up to one week after the deadline): the maximum grade is 50%.
- After one week, the grade will be 0% for that assignment.
- If you cannot attend class, you are still responsible for submitting your assignment by the deadline.

Attendance/Class participation. Class participation is mandatory. This is not a general core class but a specialty class, so you are expected to come to every meeting with the exception of emergencies, of course. I can tolerate up to 6 hours of absence without any grade drop. Your attendance grade will be affected if your absences pass beyond this limit, according to the table

below. Please be prompt as well; late arrivals (after the first 15 minutes) will count as a 1-hour absence. After a total of 18 hours of absence, you will receive a letter grade of FZ.

I also expect you to come to class prepared with the material in hand. This will directly affect your participation grade.

1 absence (2 hours)	16 points
2 absences (4 hours)	16 points
3 absences (6 hours)	16 points
4 absences (8 hours)	15 points
5 absences (10 hours)	12 points
6 absences (12 hours)	9 points
7 absences (14 hours)	5 points
8 absences (16 hours)	0 points
9 absences (18 hours)	FZ

Academic Integrity. This is an analysis course, and all the analyses you are required to do must be your own. Please use external sources only to compare and discuss different points of view if you use other authors' ideas, words, theories, graphics, and analyses without giving credit, it is considered plagiarism. Even if you paraphrase someone else's idea with your own words, you still must cite the original source. Failure to correctly cite external resources may result in failure of the course. This is an advanced-level undergraduate course; any violation of academic integrity standards will be taken seriously. Students are expected to demonstrate independence, critical thinking, and scholarly responsibility in all submitted work.

IMPORTANT DATES.

November 10th: Midterm analysis due

December 22nd: Sonata Movement due and performance

January 6th: Final Paper due

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

#	DATE	Subject	Reading	Assignment
1	15 Sept. Mon	Introduction Formal Functions vs Dialogical Form		
2	18 Sept. Thu.	Review #1 - Harmonic Prog. & Phrase Structures		
3	22 Sept. Mon.	Review #2 - cont.		Analysis Homework #1
4	25 Sept. Thu.	P-Zone #1		Composition Assignment 1 - Phrases
5	29 Sept. Mon.	P-Zone #2 - Beethoven Sonatas		Analysis Homework No. 2
6	2 Oct. Thu.	Tr-Zone #1 - MC Procedures	Chapter 3: <i>pages 23-45</i>	Composition Assignment 2 - P-Zone
7	6 Oct. Mon.	Tr-Zone #2 - Transition Types		
8	9 Oct. Thu.	Tr-Zone #3 - Beethoven Sonatas		Analysis Homework No.3
9	13 Oct. Mon.	S-Zone #1 - Basics		Composition Assignment 3 - Tr-Zone
10	16 Oct. Thu.	S-Zone #2 - Complications/EEC Deferrals		
11	20 Oct. Mon.	S-Zone #3 - Obscured MC	Chapter 3: <i>pages 45-50</i>	
12	23 Oct. Thu.	S-Zone -#4 - Beethoven Sonatas		Analysis Homework No.4
-	27 Oct. Mon.	NO CLASSES		
13	30 Oct. Thu.	C-Zone #1		Composition Assignment 4 - S-Zone
14	3 Nov. Mon.	C-Zone #2 - Beethoven Sonatas		Analysis Homework No.5
15	6 Nov. Thu.	Trimodular Block		
16	10 Nov. Mon.	Midterm Analysis and Presentations		
17	13 Nov. Thu.	Developmental Space #1 - Pre-core/Core		Composition Assignment 5 - C-Zone
18	17 Nov. Mon.	Developmental Space #2 - Rotations		
19	20 Nov. Thu.	No Class		Analysis Homework No.6
20	24 Nov. Mon.	Developmental Space #3 - Beethoven Sonatas		Composition Assignment 6 - Pre-core

#	DATE	Subject	Reading	Assignment
21	27 Nov. Thu.	Recapitulatory Space #1 - Crux and ESC		Analysis Homework No.7
22	1 Dec. Mon.	Recapitulatory Space #2 - Non-normative		
23	4 Dec. Thu.	Parageneric Spaces - Slow Introduction & Coda		Composition Assignment 7 - Full Dev.
24	8 Dec. Mon.	Other Sonata Types and Other Sonata Types		
25	11 Dec. Thu.	Concerto: Type 5 Sonata		
26	15 Dec. Mon.	After Beethoven - Schubert		Composition Assignment 8 - Rec.
27	18 Dec. Thu.	After Beethoven - Brahms and Mahler		
28	22 Dec. Mon.	Projects presented and performed		Composition Assignment - Final Presentation

Expanded Bibliography

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